

LIFE IN A... METRO
A dilapidated tenement in Mumbai's Kamathipura

But, gradually, this area developed an unpalatable reputation of sorts due to the flesh trade operating out of some of its lanes. Mumbai's position as a port city and military centre, coupled with the high numbers of migrant workers, led to a rise in prostitution. In colonial-era Kamathipura, apart from Indian prostitutes, it was not uncommon to find European women engaged in the trade. Then, there were the Chinese residents, their social clubs and opium and gambling dens.

Kamathipura has left much of this past behind. It is now a market for textiles, electronic goods, and recycled scrap, and the flesh trade is in decline here. But the stereotypes persist, much to the chagrin of residents. This also overshadows the larger contribution of Kamathipura to contemporary history. For instance, young Ambedkarites like Dhasal and fellow poet J.V. Pawar, who resided here, birthed the Dalit Panther movement in 1972 to protest against the caste system.

MHADA WILL OVERSEE THE 27.59-ACRE CLUSTER REDEVELOPMENT SCHEME IN KAMATHIPURA—THE LARGEST SUCH PROJECT IN MUMBAI, COVERING 100,000 PEOPLE

Now, keeping up with the changing times, the state cabinet in December 2022 approved a proposal to appoint the Maharashtra Housing and Area Development Authority (MHADA) as the nodal agency to oversee the 27.59-acre cluster redevelopment scheme in Kamathipura. The largest such project in Mumbai, it will cover around 943 cessed buildings (those which pay a repair cess to MHADA) with 8,238 tenants and 350 non-cessed buildings with around 5,000 tenants—the total number of residents at an estimated